Reinforcement Learning Assignment 1

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This report solves the shuttle dispatch MDP by three exact finite-state methods and implements Monte Carlo REINFORCE for CartPole-v1 and Pong-v5, with and without a prior-batch scalar baseline. All reported rewards, timings, validation values, and plots come from saved local runs.

Submission identity and evidence

GitHub username: SAMSUNYUJUN. Repository: mlds-rl-assignment1. Read-only GitHub API checks verified the authenticated account and the existing public repository, which was initially empty. Repository delivery status and authorization are recorded in ACCEPTANCE.md.

GitHub repository: https://github.com/SAMSUNYUJUN/mlds-rl-assignment1

The PDF assignment was the only teaching material supplied. Its four pages were read in full. It specifies a due date of October 26, 2026 at 11:59 pm without a timezone. No course number or additional AI-use rule has been inferred.

Frozen final-checkpoint evaluation

Model	Train episodes	Eval episodes	Mean reward	Sample SD
CartPole basic	4096	500	143.678	125.834
Pong basic	4096	500	-20.534	0.706
CartPole baseline	4096	500	423.592	83.414
Pong baseline	4096	500	-19.806	1.046

Total: 2,000 complete held-out evaluation episodes, 1,290,169 evaluation environment steps, and 10,689,593 formal training steps. Each model was frozen before its final evaluation. The policy samples its action distribution throughout evaluation; no argmax or checkpoint reselection uses these 500 rewards.

Reward means and sample standard deviations describe raw undiscounted complete-episode totals. They are distinct from the discounted optimization objective and from the variance of a gradient estimator. All four models are single-training-seed experiments; comparisons describe these runs rather than population-level causal effects.

1. Shuttle model and finite enumeration

State s is the observed queue size in {0,...,200} at a decision epoch. Action a in {0,1} means wait or dispatch one shuttle. Define q(s,a)=max(s-15a,0). The timing is: observe s, choose a, serve up to 15 passengers, charge dispatch plus holding for passengers still waiting, then add an independent uniform arrival A in {1,...,5}. New arrivals are first eligible for service at the next epoch.

```
c(s,a) = 100 a + 2 max(s - 15 a, 0)
s_next = min(200, max(s - 15 a, 0) + A)
P(s_next=j | s,a) = (1/5) sum_{A=1}^5 1[j=s_next(s,a,A)]
V_pi(s) = E_pi[sum_{t=0}^infinity 0.95^t c(s_t,a_t) | s_0=s]
```

All shuttle values are nonnegative discounted costs to minimize, not negative rewards. Empty or underfilled dispatch is allowed, costs 100, and takes min(s,15) passengers. At most one shuttle leaves per epoch. The artificial queue cap discards arrivals above 200 without an overflow penalty; equal clipped successor states accumulate probability. These are explicit modeling assumptions, not additional PDF quotations.

No further classroom definition of Enumeration was supplied. I therefore enumerate the two actions and five arrival branches in finite-horizon backward recursion, with T=500 and terminal V_T(s)=0. This evaluates the decision tree through shared subproblems instead of enumerating exponentially many complete 500-step trajectories.

```
V_t(s) = min_a { c(s,a) + 0.95 sum_j P(j|s,a) V_{t+1}(j) }
V_500(s)=0; t=499,...,0
```

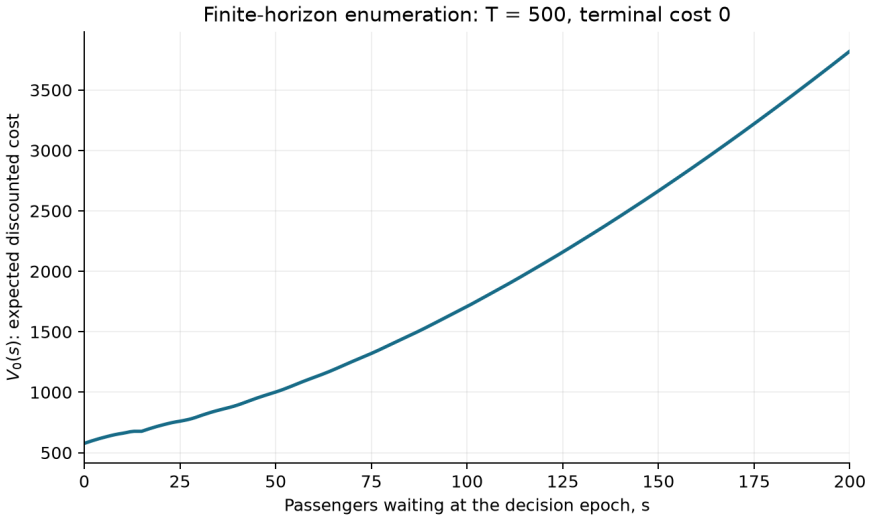


Figure 1. Finite-horizon enumeration: V_0(s) for T=500, terminal continuation cost zero.

At s=0 the computed cost is 576.670168; at s=200 it is 3,821.586477. More initial waiting increases cost through holding and the number of successive dispatches required.

2. Infinite-horizon shuttle solutions

Value iteration starts at V=0 and repeatedly applies the minimum-cost Bellman operator until the maximum successive change is at most 1e-10. The contraction factor is 0.95. Policy iteration starts with never dispatching, solves (I-gamma P_pi)V=c_pi in float64, and improves all actions until the policy stops changing. Ties are resolved toward wait.

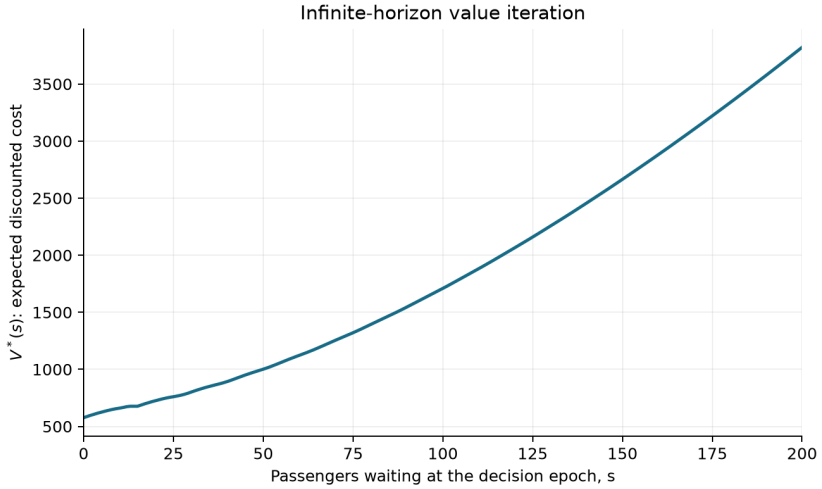


Figure 2. Value iteration converged in 519 iterations; the values are discounted costs.

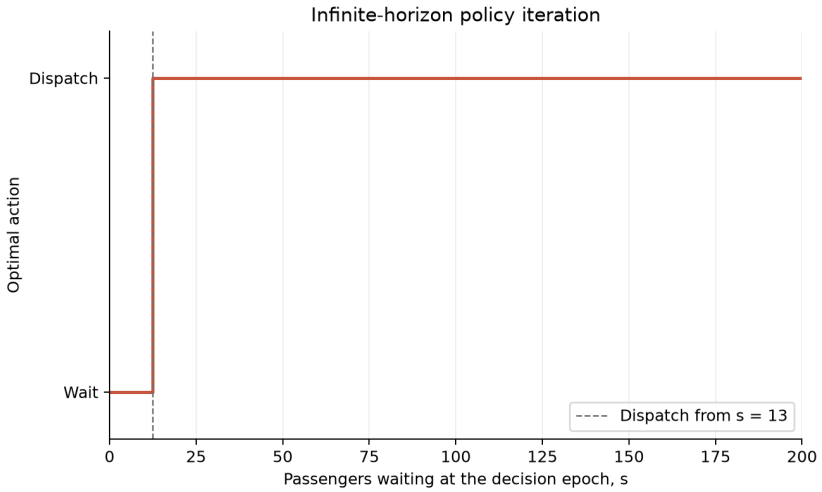


Figure 3. Policy iteration converged in 6 improvements/evaluations: wait below 13, dispatch from 13 through 200.

The resulting threshold 13 is below capacity 15. Waiting for a full shuttle is not generally optimal because accumulated holding cost can outweigh unused capacity. The numerical minimum action-value gap is 3.778004, attained at state 12; the selected policy is not a near-tie artifact.

3. Shuttle validation and edge cases

```
.venv/bin/python src/shuttle.py all
.venv/bin/python src/shuttle.py validate
```

Test purpose	Theory and running method	Observed result
Independent small decision tree	A separate recursive exhaustive tree must match the matrix recurrence for all states and horizons.	40 comparisons; max error 0.000.
Hand-derived timing and boundaries	Empty/underfilled service, K, K+1, and cap aggregation must match manual successors/costs.	Max error 0.000 in 8 cases.
Deterministic no-arrival control	With A=0, enumerate the number of immediate dispatches followed by waiting forever.	Max value error 1.80e-09.
Optimality certificate and solver agreement	Small Bellman residual implies small fixed-point error; VI and PI must agree.	VI residual 9.41e-11; PI 9.09e-13.
Finite/infinite horizon tail	Nonnegative omitted tail bounds V_infinity - V_0 at T=500.	Max difference 4.94e-09.
Nonoptimal policy reference	Optimal costs cannot exceed a fixed never-dispatch policy.	At s=200 cost improves by 4,178.414.

The small-tree oracle uses eight states and horizons 0 through 4, recursively visiting every action/outcome subtree without transition tensors or memoization. It therefore tests the expectation/minimization independently of the main solver. The no-arrival test changes the original arrival law only for validation and compares against an analytic discounted dispatch/wait cost.

The maximum VI/PI value difference is 1.86e-09 with 0 policy disagreements. The VI residual gives a sup-norm value-error bound residual/(1-gamma)=1.88e-09. The finite/infinite difference is below the independent geometric tail bound 6.84e-08.

State/action	Charged cost	Successors or cap probability
0 / wait	0	1,2,3,4,5; each 0.2
0 / dispatch	100	same successors as waiting; strictly dominated
14 or 15 / dispatch	100	1,2,3,4,5; each 0.2
16 / dispatch	102	2,3,4,5,6; each 0.2
198 / wait	396	P(199)=0.2; P(200)=0.8
200 / dispatch	470	186,187,188,189,190; each 0.2

These checks support the stated capped-queue MDP. They do not validate the realism of dropping overflow passengers. A different overflow rule or additional dispatch constraints defines a different decision problem.

4. REINFORCE objective and implementation

For an episode of length L, the training objective discounts rewards from the episode start. G_t is return-to-go with time measured relative to t. Evaluation instead uses R=sum_t r_t without discount. CartPole gamma=0.95; Pong gamma=0.99.

```
J(theta) = E_pi[sum_{t=0}^{L-1} gamma^t r_t]
G_t = sum_{u=t}^{L-1} gamma^(u-t) r_u
loss = -(1/(100 B)) sum_{episode i=1}^B sum_{t=0}^{L_i-1}
gamma^t log pi_theta(a_it | x_it) detach(G_it - b)
```

The absolute-time gamma^t factor matches the declared episode-start objective; it is separate from the discount inside G_t. Time steps are summed and complete episodes are averaged, with the same fixed positive scale 100 in every model. The basic estimator sets b=0 and never subtracts an episode/batch mean or applies z-score normalization. Adam minimizes the loss; clipping bounds the aggregate gradient norm at 10. These optimizer choices are recorded rather than claimed to preserve an unclipped update exactly.

Environment	Policy input and network	Episode completion
CartPole-v1	Raw 4-vector -> Linear(4,64) -> Tanh -> Linear(64,2); sampled left/right.	Natural failure or official 500-step TimeLimit.
ALE/Pong-v5	Game RGB image -> PDF crop/downsample/background mask -> 80x80 frame difference -> Linear(6400,64) -> ReLU -> Linear(64,2). Outputs map to environment actions [2,3].	Natural game end or official ALE 108,000-frame cap; no point/rally boundaries.

Network initialization uses PyTorch default nn.Linear parameter initialization after manual_seed: matched methods use seed 101 for CartPole and 202 for Pong, without pretrained weights. Adam uses betas=(0.9,0.999), eps=1e-8 and weight_decay=0 under the pinned PyTorch 2.14.1 runtime. Reset/image-history initialization is separate from weight initialization.

The installed official registry resolves the requested Pong-v5 as ALE/Pong-v5 (Gymnasium 1.4.0, ale-py 0.12.1). The six actual action meanings are NOOP, FIRE, RIGHT, LEFT, RIGHTFIRE, LEFTFIRE. The implementation selects only RIGHT and LEFT, indices 2 and 3. Inputs are images, not RAM.

Pong uses frameskip=4, sticky action probability=0.25, mode=0, difficulty=0, and the minimal six-action space. Crop rows 35:195, downsample both dimensions by 2, use the red channel, erase colors 144/109 and map other nonzero pixels to 1. Input is current minus previous binary frame, with a zero difference at reset. No frame stack, FIRE/NOOP wrapper, point-based termination, reward clipping, or custom episode shortening is used.

Rollouts run without autograd; the policy parameters remain fixed for the entire update batch. Observations/actions are stored on CPU (Pong observations as int8), then log probabilities are recomputed in bounded chunks of 512. Gradients accumulate over all chunks; exactly one optimizer step occurs after the entire batch. Thus recomputation uses the sampling policy and does not retain long episode graphs. Evaluation uses inference mode with no gradient recording.

5. Local benchmark, budgets, and checkpoints

All runs were executed on the verified native arm64 Apple M4 Pro MacBook Pro with 24 GB unified memory, macOS 15.6.1, Python 3.12.14, and PyTorch 2.14.1. The environment inspection reports machine=arm64, MPS available=True. No remote or paid compute was used. Shuttle and CartPole use CPU.

Pong CPU/MPS timing uses the same 64-unit policy, image preprocessing, complete-episode environment configuration, seed sequence, batch size, loss, and Adam update. Throughput includes rollout, Python environment stepping, preprocessing, inference, return calculation, and updates. Device selection uses measured end-to-end environment steps per second rather than matrix throughput alone.

Device	Duration	Env steps	Steps/s	Mean update	Peak RSS
cpu	5.0 min	1,264,795	4,203.1	0.04 s	581.2 MiB
mps	5.0 min	969,323	3,217.4	0.09 s	902.3 MiB

Selected Pong device: cpu. highest measured full-rollout-plus-update environment steps per second. Each device trial runs in a separate process, so peak RSS is an independent process high-water mark. MPS allocation counters in data/benchmark/decision.json are additional device-memory snapshots, not independent physical-memory peaks.

Run	Seed	Episodes	Batch	Adam LR	Device	Train time
CartPole basic	101	4096	8	0.01	cpu	10.48 s
Pong basic	202	4096	8	0.001	cpu	16.1 min
CartPole baseline	101	4096	8	0.01	cpu	10.28 s
Pong baseline	202	4096	8	0.001	cpu	15.8 min

Pilot attempts (excluded from formal results)

Pilot	Episodes	Adam LR	Last up-to-100 mean	Time
pilot_cartpole	80	0.01	34.025	0.10 s
pilot_pong_lr0p001	128	0.001	-20.410	31.77 s
pilot_pong_lr0p01	128	0.01	-20.860	28.52 s

Pong uses Adam 0.001 after 128-episode matched tuning pilots: mean diagnostic action entropy was 0.5403 nats at 0.01 and 0.6879 at 0.001. Both lost; neither saturated above probability .999. The lower rate conservatively preserves exploration. Eight diagnostic games per rate are weak single-seed evidence, not proof of final superiority. CartPole retains the default 0.01.

Gradient clipping bound 10 was monitored: clipped updates / all updates = CartPole basic 0/512; Pong basic 0/512; CartPole baseline 0/512; Pong baseline 0/512. A zero count means clipping did not alter the updates in that run.

Formal training stops at the recorded episode budgets; smoke tests and timed benchmark episodes are excluded. The frozen checkpoint is the final model at that budget, recorded in FROZEN.json with a SHA-256 checksum before held-out evaluation. Neither the 500 final evaluation rewards nor their histograms select a checkpoint. Hyperparameter choices, initial failures, and the budget decision are documented in docs/experiment_budget.md; each run preserves its effective configuration.

Checkpoints include policy, Adam, episode/step counts, baseline, time and update count. Independent episode seeds permit batch-boundary recovery. Training sampling_policy_update identifies the policy before its consuming optimizer update; checkpoint tags are logical sampling-update labels, not retained filenames. Evaluation rows map to the frozen file hash. Atomic saves/log trimming prevent duplicate uncommitted batches.

6. CartPole basic: actual results

4,096 train episodes; 1,384,029 steps; seed 101; Adam 0.01; cpu. First to last 100 means: raw R 36.580 to 453.460; discounted J 15.3171 to 19.8185. The moving window grows from 1 to 100, then stays 100.

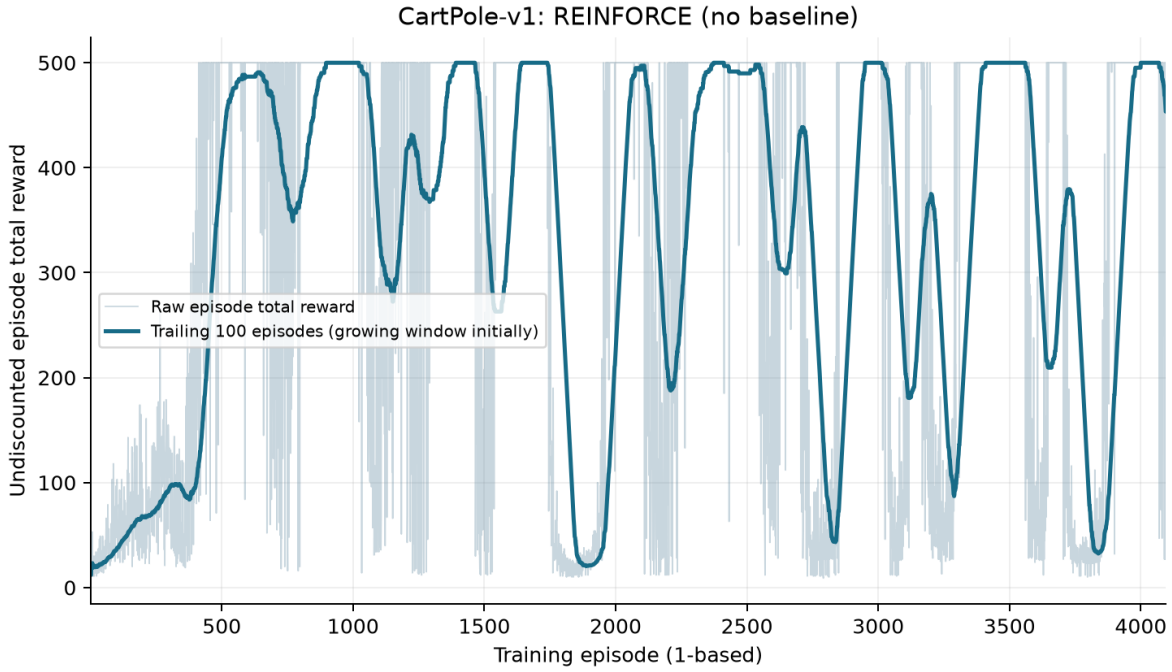


Figure 4. CartPole basic: raw training reward and trailing 100-episode mean.

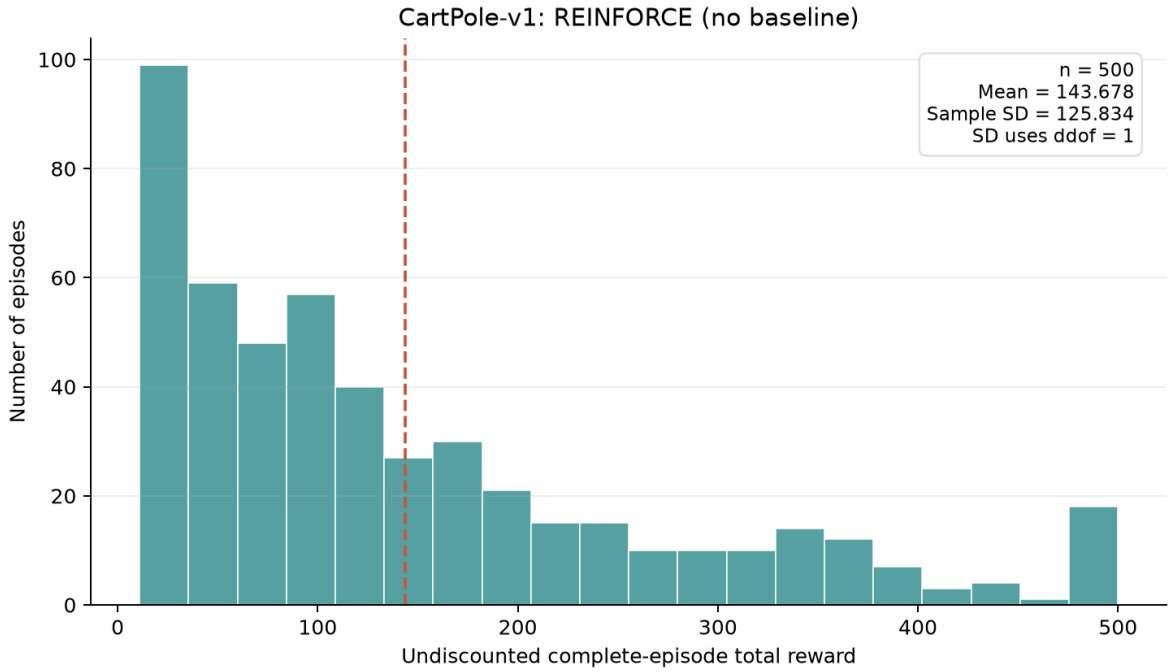


Figure 5. CartPole basic: 500 frozen-policy complete-episode rewards.

Final mean=143.678; sample SD=125.834 (ddof=1); range [11, 500]; mean length=143.7 steps. Exclusive end cases: natural only 485, time-limit only 15, both flags 0; total 500. Flags may coincide on CartPole step 500.

7. Pong basic: actual results

4,096 train episodes; 4,016,974 steps; seed 202; Adam 0.001; cpu. First to last 100 means: raw R -20.500 to -20.510; discounted J -1.4373 to -1.1791. The moving window grows from 1 to 100, then stays 100.

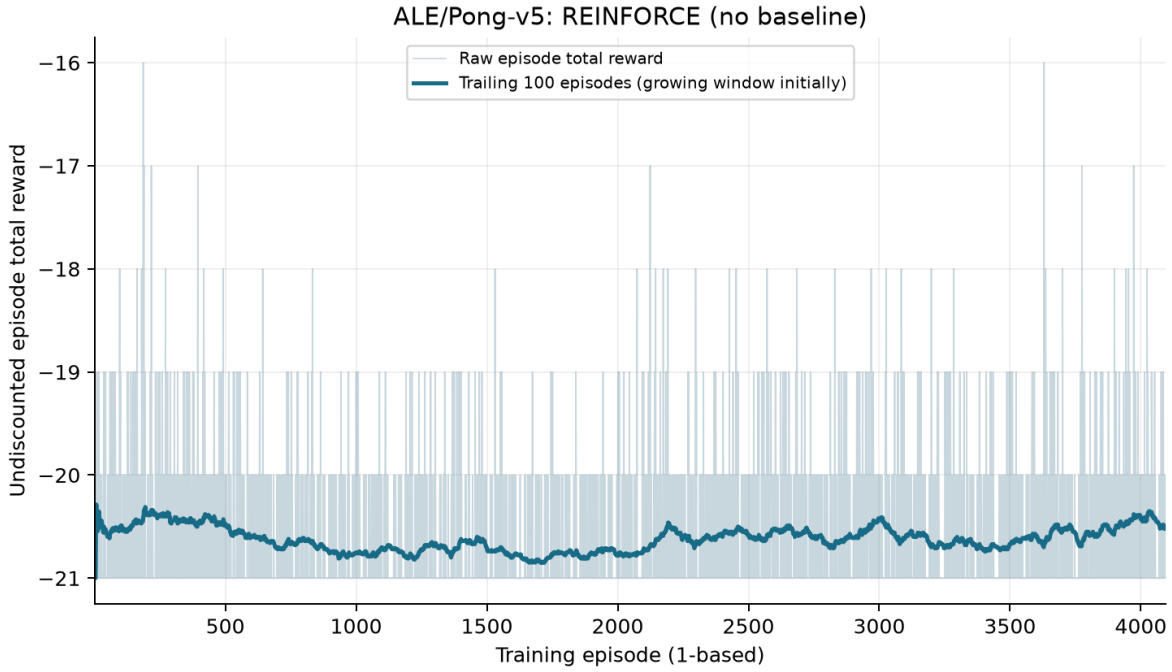


Figure 6. Pong basic: raw training reward and trailing 100-episode mean.

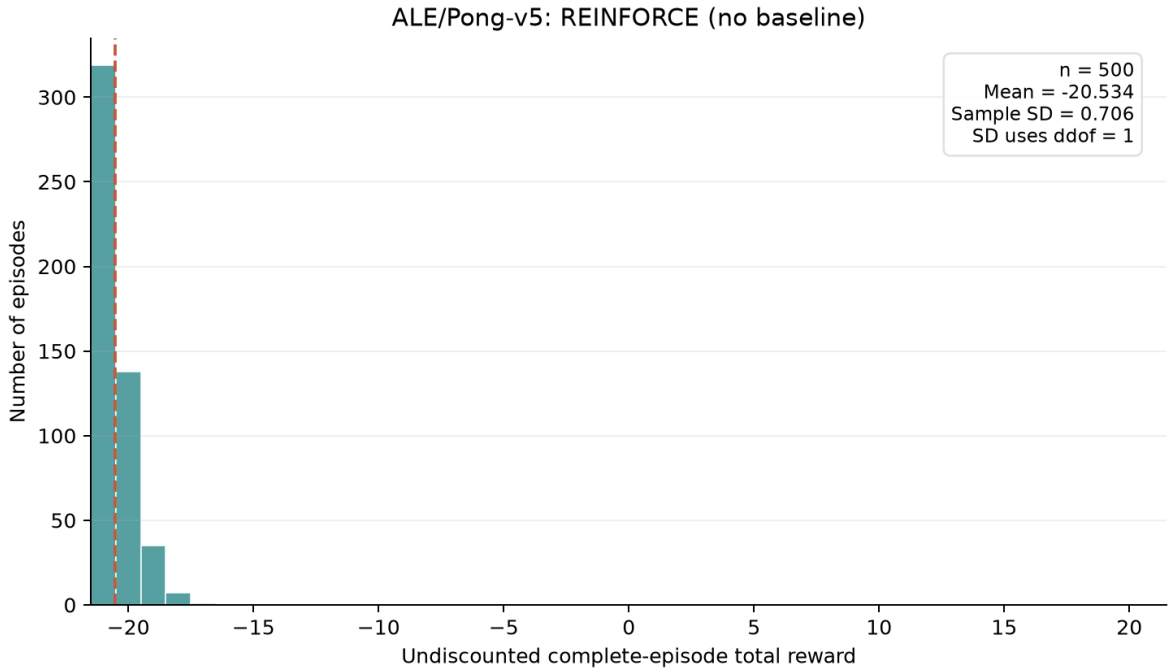


Figure 7. Pong basic: 500 frozen-policy complete-episode rewards.

Final mean=-20.534; sample SD=0.706 (ddof=1); range [-21, -17]; mean length=1,019.4 steps. Exclusive end cases: natural only 500, time-limit only 0, both flags 0; total 500. Flags may coincide on CartPole step 500.

8. CartPole baseline: actual results

4,096 train episodes; 1,290,047 steps; seed 101; Adam 0.01; cpu. First to last 100 means: raw R 39.490 to 404.090; discounted J 15.7873 to 20.0000. The moving window grows from 1 to 100, then stays 100.

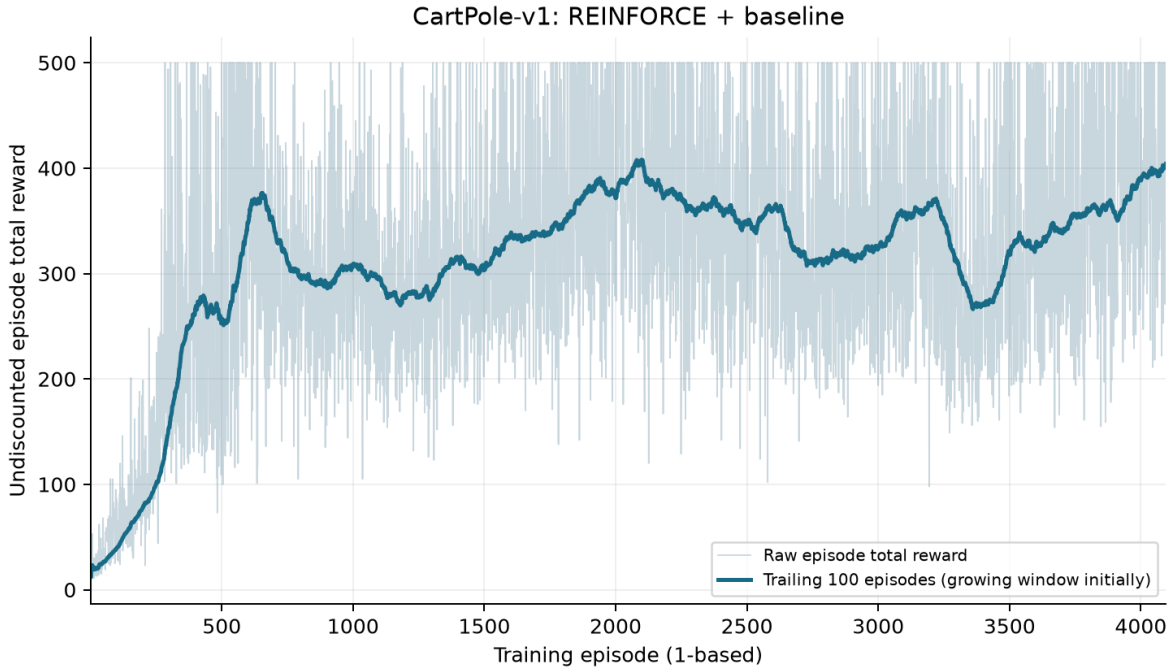


Figure 8. CartPole baseline: raw training reward and trailing 100-episode mean.

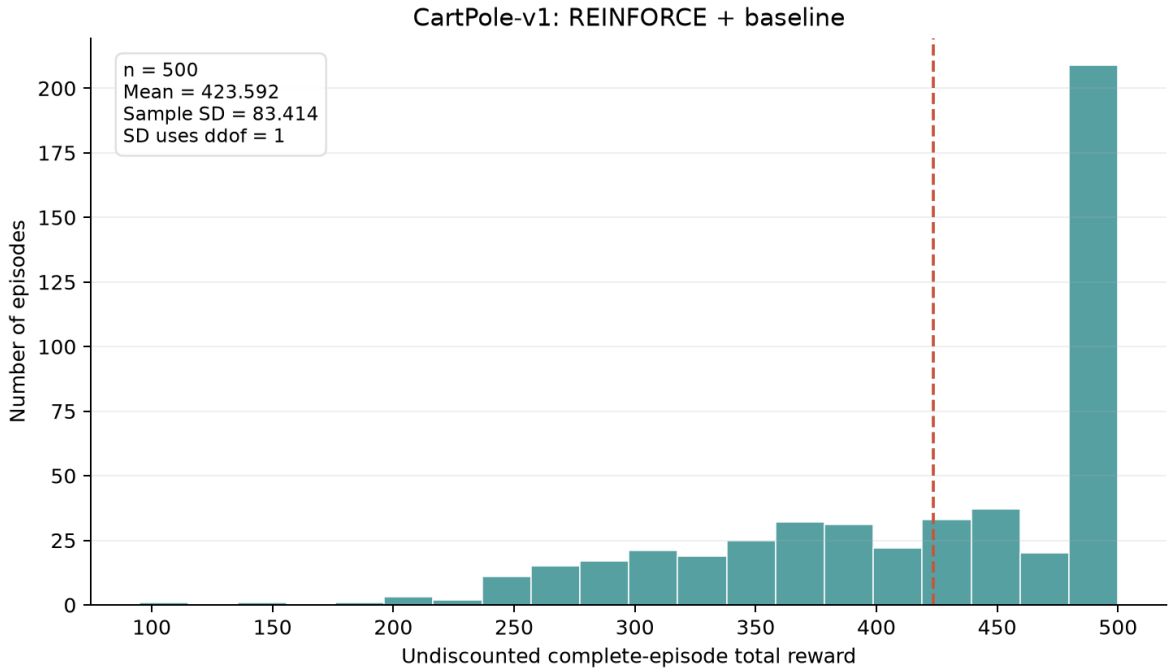


Figure 9. CartPole baseline: 500 frozen-policy complete-episode rewards.

Final mean=423.592; sample SD=83.414 (ddof=1); range [95, 500]; mean length=423.6 steps. Exclusive end cases: natural only 311, time-limit only 187, both flags 2; total 500. Flags may coincide on CartPole step 500.

9. Pong baseline: actual results

4,096 train episodes; 3,998,543 steps; seed 202; Adam 0.001; cpu. First to last 100 means: raw R -20.530 to -19.980; discounted J -1.4323 to -0.2470. The moving window grows from 1 to 100, then stays 100.

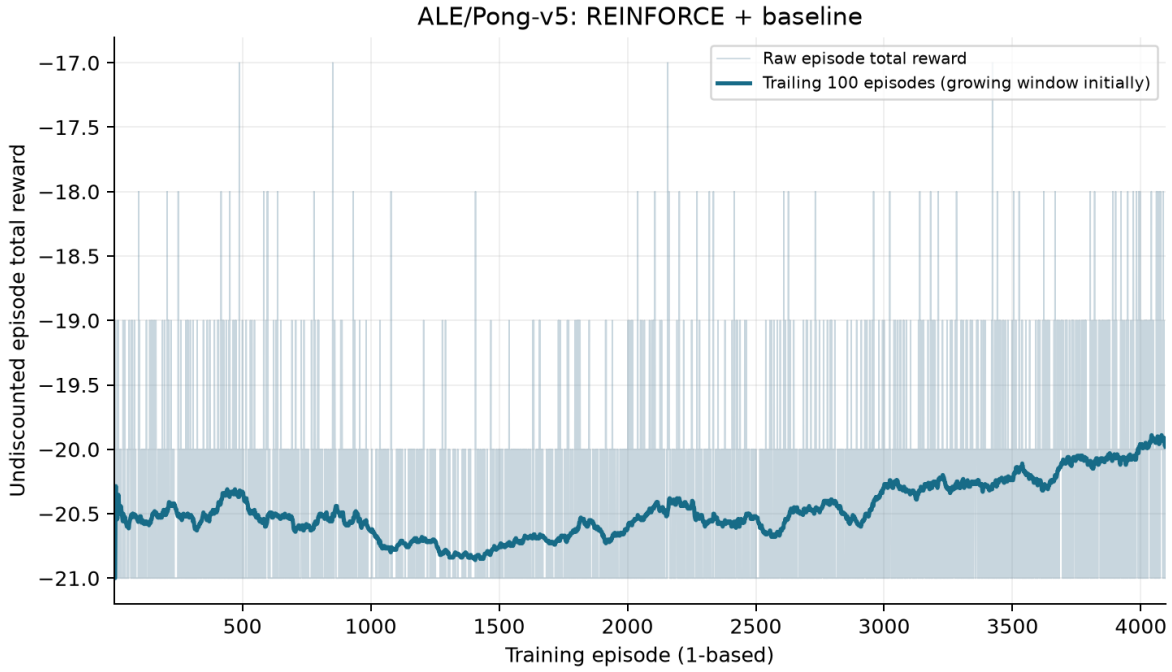


Figure 10. Pong baseline: raw training reward and trailing 100-episode mean.

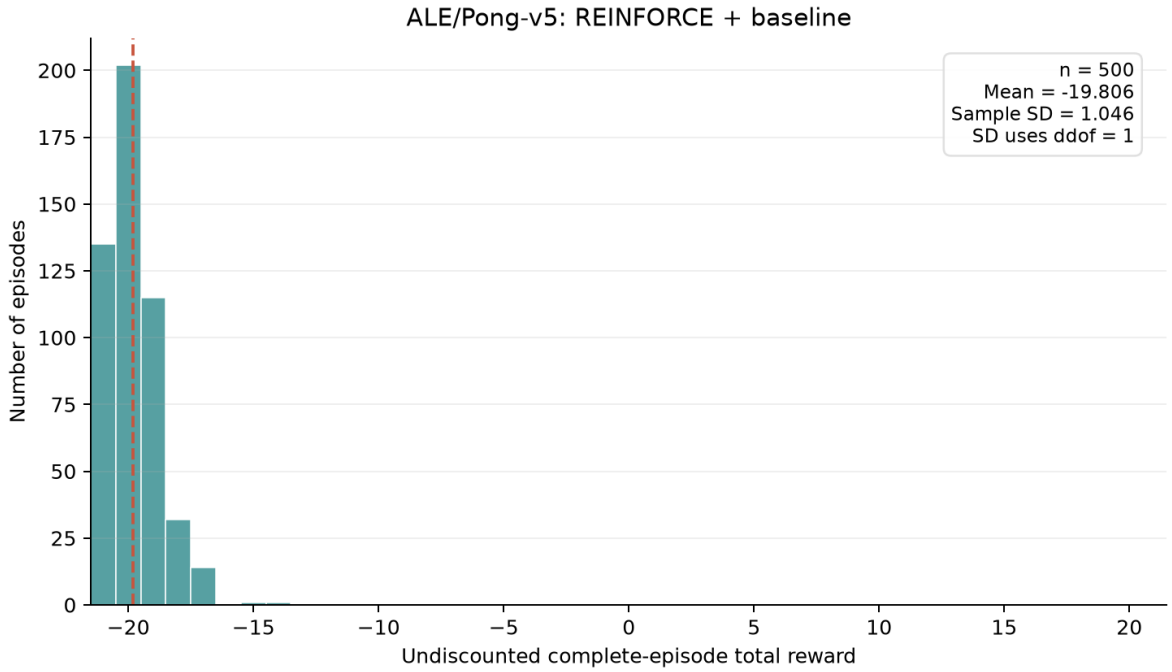


Figure 11. Pong baseline: 500 frozen-policy complete-episode rewards.

Final mean=-19.806; sample SD=1.046 (ddof=1); range [-21, -14]; mean length=993.6 steps. Exclusive end cases: natural only 500, time-limit only 0, both flags 0; total 500. Flags may coincide on CartPole step 500.

10. Policy-gradient correctness evidence

```
.venv/bin/python -m src.validate_rl --output data/validation/rl.json
```

Hand trajectory and objective weighting

Purpose: detect return indexing, terminal errors and objective mismatch. Theory: rewards [1,2,3], gamma=.95 yield G=[5.6075,4.85,3], with objective weights [1,.95,.9025]. Method: compare the trainer recurrence against direct sums and hand values, including gamma=0/1, empty and one-step cases. Actual maximum error is 8.88e-16. Interpretation: terminal continuation is zero and the final reward is included once.

Exact trajectory enumeration and update direction

Purpose: validate the stochastic estimator without Monte Carlo error. Theory: three independent Bernoulli actions with p=.35 and rewards [1+2a0,-.5+3a1,2-a2] have dJ/dtheta=p(1-p)(2+3 gamma-gamma^2)=0.89805625. Method: enumerate all eight trajectories and exact probabilities. Actual mean estimator is 0.89805625. Omitting gamma^t instead gives 0.91000000, a bias of 0.01194375.

The float64 PyTorch policy-loss derivative is -0.89805625; the central finite-difference objective derivative is 0.89805625. One small SGD step raises J from 3.711625 to 3.719701. This verifies the loss sign, not Adam convergence in Pong.

Real CartPole first-ten-step trace

Purpose: connect the return equations to real state/action/reward transitions. A separate uniform policy uses CartPole reset seed 74219 and Python action seed 74220. It runs the entire episode before returns are calculated; displaying ten rows does not truncate training or evaluation.

t	Observation (x, xdot, angle, angledot)	a	r	Return-to-go
0	-0.0352, -0.0335, 0.0192, -0.0136	1	1.0	18.011195
1	-0.0359, 0.1613, 0.0189, -0.3001	1	1.0	17.906521
2	-0.0327, 0.3562, 0.0129, -0.5868	0	1.0	17.796338
3	-0.0255, 0.1609, 0.0012, -0.2900	0	1.0	17.680356
4	-0.0223, -0.0343, -0.0046, 0.0030	1	1.0	17.558269
5	-0.0230, 0.1609, -0.0045, -0.2911	1	1.0	17.429757
6	-0.0198, 0.3561, -0.0104, -0.5852	1	1.0	17.294481
7	-0.0127, 0.5514, -0.0221, -0.8812	0	1.0	17.152085
8	-0.0016, 0.3565, -0.0397, -0.5955	0	1.0	17.002195
9	0.0055, 0.1620, -0.0516, -0.3156	0	1.0	16.844416

The complete diagnostic episode length is 45; total reward is 45.0. Its full states, actions, rewards, termination flags, discounted weights and returns are saved in data/validation/rl.json. For +1 CartPole rewards, the geometric return formula independently checks the recurrence. This diagnostic is excluded from the formal evaluation.

11. Production trainer and local controls

Purpose: verify that the actual imported trainer implements the validated estimator, memory-bounded update, baseline timing, preprocessing, and checkpoint recovery. This test calls src.rl.update rather than a parallel demonstration implementation.

Exact complete trajectory enumeration at p=.5 gives dJ/dtheta=.986875; /100 loss and SGD .01 gives theta=.0000986875 for b=0 and b=2. Chunking and serialization must preserve the update.

Method: Import src.rl; run real update() on all eight trajectories; independently calculate a single-graph Adam update; verify synthetic image pixels; save/load model+Adam+EMA between actual CartPole batches with deterministic episode seeds.

Production check	Actual quantitative evidence	Interpretation
Return recurrence	8.88e-16 max absolute error	The production function agrees with direct hand sums.
Exact expected update, b=0	9.87e-05 vs 9.87e-05	Loss sign, gamma weights, fixed scale and batch average agree.
Exact expected update, b=2	9.87e-05 vs 9.87e-05	A fixed baseline preserves the expected update.
EMA next batch	2.0790972831 vs theory 2.0790972831	The update uses b=2, then assigns the completed-batch target to the next batch.
Chunked vs independent graph	2.98e-08 parameter max error; 2.87e-09 loss error	Even chunk size 1 reproduces the independent full graph within float32 precision.
Checkpoint roundtrip	Next rollouts identical=True; parameter max error=0.000	Saved model, Adam and baseline reproduce an actual next CPU update.
Image semantics	Test mask pixels=[0, 0, 1, 1]; signed difference range=[-1, 0]	Background removal and negative motion pixels survive preprocessing without mutating the raw image.

Actual CartPole rollout lengths in the checkpoint experiment were 17, 16, 16, 45, 20, 26, 21, 14. The resumed baseline was exactly equal=True. These are update-boundary CPU checks; they do not claim bitwise CPU/MPS equality or recovery inside an unfinished episode.

Additional fixed-checkpoint random-policy and gradient diagnostics are saved in data/validation/gradient_diagnostic.json. Their measured results and interpretation appear below.

12. Fixed-checkpoint empirical diagnostics

Purpose: measure the implemented saved scalar baseline on actual learned-policy trajectories, and compare task behavior with an uninformed policy. Theory: a scalar fixed before actions preserves the expected gradient but can increase or reduce estimator variance. No optimizer or parameter update occurs; these diagnostics are collected after checkpoints are frozen.

```
.venv/bin/python -m src.gradient_diagnostic --run runs/cartpole_baseline --run runs/pong_baseline --episodes 32
--device cpu
```

```
g_i(b) = sum_t gamma^t grad log pi(a_it | x_it) (G_it-b)/100
trace(sample Cov) = sum_i ||g_i - mean(g)||^2 / (n-1)
```

Method: use the same complete trajectories for b=0 and the saved EMA, with diagnostic seed base 92000000. Recompute float32 production-policy log probabilities in bounded chunks, before clipping and Adam. Float64 online vector moments avoid storing an episode-by-parameter matrix. Raw paired norms, projections and episode records are retained.

Game	n	Saved b	Trace Cov b=0	Trace Cov EMA	Ratio EMA/0
cartpole	32	19.999752	1.598726	2.45e-10	1.53e-10
pong	32	-0.900326	0.047282	0.025458	0.5384

Cartpole: the saved baseline gives lower sampled gradient variance in these 32 episodes. Diagnostic mean raw reward is 424.812 and mean length 424.8. Parameters unchanged=True; natural terminations=23; official truncations=9. A finite-sample difference between mean gradients does not establish bias because empirical baseline scores need not average to zero.

Pong: the saved baseline gives lower sampled gradient variance in these 32 episodes. Diagnostic mean raw reward is -20.188 and mean length 935.2. Parameters unchanged=True; natural terminations=32; official truncations=0. A finite-sample difference between mean gradients does not establish bias because empirical baseline scores need not average to zero.

Separate uniform random-policy reference

Game	n	Mean raw reward	Sample SD	Mean length
cartpole	32	20.344	8.295	20.3
pong	32	-20.594	0.712	1,041.8

The reference uses zero logits, the same environment/action set and full termination, graph-free collection, and distinct seed base 93000000. Its raw rewards are excluded from all four final evaluation histograms. These small controls support descriptive interpretation; they are not a statistical test of superiority over independent training runs.

CartPole explanation: many long-survival trajectories have early return-to-go almost equal to 1/(1-.95)=20, close to the saved b=19.9997517. Subtraction removes a nearly constant score-function nuisance. The true episode-start discounted survival gradient can itself be very small because late rewards receive .95^t weight. This explains a very large measured variance reduction without proving a universal baseline advantage. Exact toy identities support unbiasedness; 32 sampled means alone cannot establish or refute it.

These diagnostics do not use the final held-out 500-episode samples to select a checkpoint. Small diagnostic sample counts support mechanism checks, not definitive ranking of the four trained policies.

13. Baseline mechanism and evidence

The baseline is a scalar EMA carried from earlier complete batches. It is initialized at zero, frozen throughout rollout and the corresponding policy update, and changes only after that update. Its target is the gamma^t-weighted mean return-to-go in the completed batch. It is constant across current states/actions; no value network or critic loss is used.

```
target_k = [sum_{i,t} gamma^t G_it] / [sum_{i,t} gamma^t]
b_(k+1) = 0.9 b_k + 0.1 target_k
advantage_it = detach(G_it - b_k)
```

Because b_k is fixed before any current-batch actions are sampled, its score-function contribution has expectation zero conditional on earlier training history. A simple return-mean target is not the exact variance-minimizing baseline, which would additionally depend on score magnitudes. Thus it can reduce or increase variance, and cannot guarantee a better final score.

Exact mechanism checks

Fixed b	Expected gradient	Gradient-estimator variance
0.0	0.89805625	6.94115144
2.0	0.89805625	2.01123013
8.0	0.89805625	16.89117447

Purpose: check action independence and variance rather than tensor shapes. Theory: fixed b leaves the expected gradient unchanged. Method: exact eight-trajectory enumeration. Actual b=2 reduces variance by 71.02%; b=8 increases it. An intentionally action-dependent baseline instead has expected gradient 2.30e-17, revealing its bias. Autograd confirms detached baseline receives no gradient (True).

A separate exact enumeration tests why the current batch is not used for its own mean-centering. With N=4 one-step samples, theory predicts factor 1-1/N=.75. Actual expectation changes from 0.45500 to 0.34125, measured ratio 0.75000. This isolates finite-batch self-dependence; the implemented prior-batch EMA avoids it.

14. Objective, scores, and evidence limits

CartPole: baseline minus basic final mean reward = 279.914; sample reward-SD change = -42.420. Architecture, environment, training budget, optimizer settings, final evaluation seeds and sampling are matched. These frozen-policy differences do not establish a general baseline benefit.

Pong: baseline minus basic final mean reward = 0.728; sample reward-SD change = 0.341. Architecture, environment, training budget, optimizer settings, final evaluation seeds and sampling are matched. The separate paired gradient diagnostic measures 46.16% lower covariance trace, while raw reward SD is higher. Gradient variance and episode-score variability are different quantities. These frozen-policy differences do not establish a general baseline benefit.

The basic CartPole curve repeatedly reaches the 500-step cap and collapses again. Its last-100 training mean is 453.460, yet the fixed final checkpoint evaluates at 143.678. A rolling training window combines trajectories from earlier sampling policies; the final Adam update follows the last logged trajectories and may alter behavior sharply. The better earlier windows were not substituted after seeing evaluation. The baseline final mean 423.592 is higher for this matched seed, but neither a stable final 500 score nor a universal method benefit is established.

The strict CartPole discounted objective saturates at 20: a 100-step trajectory has J=19.8816, while 500 steps is almost 20. Thus much of the raw-score difference between long survivals has weak discounted learning signal. This objective/score distinction and noisy episodic updates can coexist with training oscillations; the observations do not isolate a single causal explanation.

Pong model	First100 raw R	Last100 raw R	First100 J	Last100 J
Pong basic	-20.500	-20.510	-1.4373	-1.1791
Pong baseline	-20.530	-19.980	-1.4323	-0.2470

For Pong, a less negative discounted objective can reflect delaying an early loss. It need not imply a better whole-game outcome; raw scores can remain near -21. The table reports both quantities from the full formal curves. This is an objective/metric distinction, not evidence that a losing agent learned to win; only the frozen 500-game raw results quantify final game scores.

Actual Pong trace: frozen baseline diagnostic seed 92000000 ran a whole game of 859 decisions, raw reward -20, discounted J=-0.295926. The first nonzero reward was 1.0 at zero-based decision 93, contributing 0.392711 to J. Reset difference has 0 nonzero pixels; seeded first-ten-input replay identical=True. Full first-ten image counts/actions/rewards/RTG and compressed signed inputs are saved in data/validation/pong_trace.json and .npz.

Purpose/theory: verify zero reset history, exact seeded preprocessing, and gamma^t attenuation of the first sparse reward. Method: collect the complete diagnostic game, then replay just ten decisions to compare inputs without adding an evaluation episode. Interpretation: zero early rewards can coexist with nonzero return-to-go from later points. A point remains a reward inside a full game, not a terminal boundary. This trace supports credit-timing semantics rather than convergence.

Only one formal training seed per method/environment was affordable within this local experiment budget. Matched evaluation seeds improve comparability, but do not remove training-seed uncertainty. Exact toy tests verify the baseline identity and demonstrate possible variance changes, while the full games test actual behavior under the chosen sparse-reward objective. Neither evidence source substitutes for the other.

15. Reproduction, limitations, and next experiments

The README contains the actual setup, training and resumption commands. requirements-lock.txt records installed package versions; data/environment.json records the actual platform and registered environment specifications. Configurations, raw CSVs, update metrics, frozen hashes and final policies are kept per run. Train/evaluation episode IDs, seeds, raw and discounted rewards, lengths, flags, steps, times and checkpoint mappings are preserved.

```
.venv/bin/python -m src.rl inspect
.venv/bin/python src/shuttle.py all
.venv/bin/python -m src.validate_rl --output data/validation/rl.json
.venv/bin/python -m src.plot_results
.venv/bin/python -m src.build_report
```

Report rebuilding validates exactly 500 completed held-out episodes per model, disjoint training/evaluation seeds, and frozen-checkpoint SHA-256 correspondence. It reads saved observations only through recorded metrics; rebuilding figures or changing report layout never requires retraining. Training/evaluation can resume from complete committed batches after checking active processes and PROGRESS.md. The final archive excludes .venv, caches and redundant intermediate files.

Given three additional months

Run at least 10 matched training seeds per environment/method and report confidence intervals for mean reward differences and sample efficiency. Keep the present 500-episode held-out protocol and reserve separate seeds for tuning. At saved checkpoints, collect independent on-policy batches to estimate gradient covariance directly; compare the implemented EMA with a score-weighted scalar optimum and a learned state-value baseline while holding sample budgets constant.

For shuttle dispatching, vary the hard cap and model overflow as a cost or a deferred queue; compare thresholds, long-run service delays, and out-of-sample arrival laws. Validate against independently implemented tiny exact MDPs and deterministic controls. For policy gradients, verify resumed/uninterrupted equivalence, CPU/MPS gradient agreement on saved batches, and explicit terminal-versus-time-limit cases. Test reward timing and gamma sensitivity without changing the required formal environment.

For Pong, inspect first-score timing, sticky-action effects, frame-difference reset/boundary behavior and sparse-reward credit assignment. Compare compatible simple image-feature policies and small learning-rate/batch-size grids using tuning seeds. A strict episode-start discounted objective with gamma=.99 gives little weight to late Pong scores; study that sensitivity transparently rather than silently replacing it with another algorithm or a different objective.

Primary references and retained evidence

Assignment source: mlds_assignment1.pdf in the project root (four pages).

Official ALE Pong environment

Official Gymnasium CartPole environment

Method details: docs/shuttle_method.md and docs/rl_validation.md. Chinese study guide: docs/LEARNING_ZH.md. Acceptance/evidence checklist: REQUIREMENTS.md. Hardware, GitHub verification limits and permitted actions: USER_CONTEXT.md. Continuous state and recovery: PROGRESS.md. Raw scientific results remain the source of truth when interpreting all eleven required plot contents.